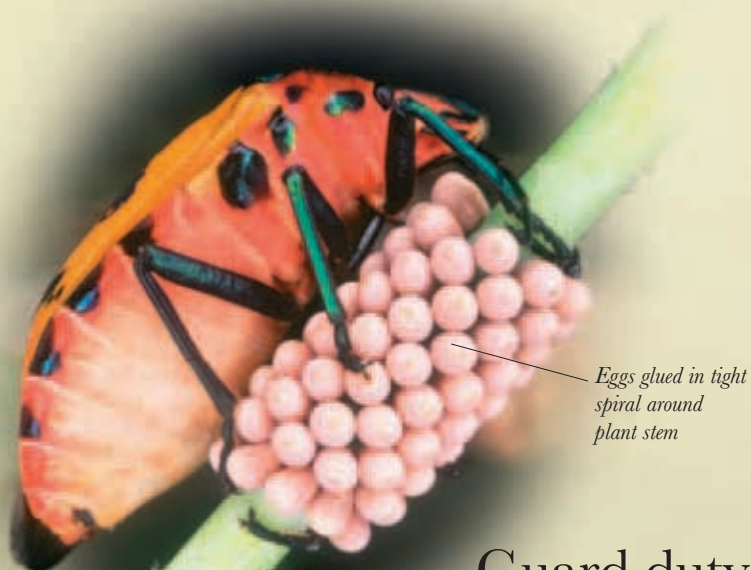




Eggs glued in tight spiral around plant stem

Guard duty

In the insect world, caring parents are rare. This plant bug is an exception. She guards her clutch of eggs around the clock. Once her young have hatched, she stays with them until they have shed their cases, or exoskeletons, for the first time. After that, the young bugs are on their own.

Foster parent feeds cuckoo, not realizing that it is an impostor

Rapidly growing cuckoo is too big to fit into nest



Baby boom

Instead of raising their own young, some animals trick others into doing all the work for them. The common cuckoo does this by laying eggs in the nests of smaller birds. The young cuckoo hatches first, and pushes all the other eggs or hatchlings out of the nest. From then on, it gets all the food for itself.



Adult echidna, or spiny anteater

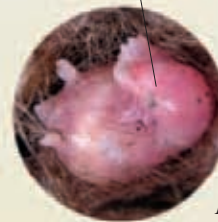
Monotreme milk

Monotremes have a unique way of breeding. They lay eggs, but they raise their young in a pouch. The young feed on their mother's milk, not from teats as in other mammals, but from glands tucked away in a groove in her pouch. These strange animals include the platypus and several kinds of echidna. They live only in New Guinea and Australia.

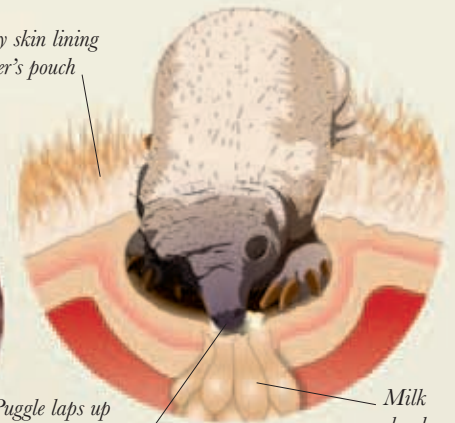
Folds of pouch held back to show egg



Recently hatched puggle inside pouch



Hairy skin lining mother's pouch



Puggle laps up milk inside groove

Milk gland

Echidna egg

The egg is about the size of a grape, with a large yolk and a leathery shell. The female incubates it in her pouch for 10–11 days.

Hatchling puggle

The young echidna, or puggle, tears open the shell using a sharp point on its snout. At this early age, it is completely blind and has no spines.

Lapping up milk

The puggle stays in the pouch for about 55 days. The puggle has no teat to latch onto, so it laps up the mother's milk as it oozes out into a groove.

Mighty mouth

Peering out of a rocky crevice, one of the sea's most peculiar parents shows off a mouthful of eggs. He is a jawfish, and he collects the eggs when the female spawns. For more than a week, he protects the eggs and pumps water over them to supply them with oxygen, keeping them healthy. He releases them when they are ready to hatch.

Dark eyes of developing fish already visible within eggs

